

Part II: Crises and Change—1774-1789

Louis XVI's coronation in 1775 coincided with the Flour War—not actually a war, but a series of riots and protests in France over the price of bread that had to be put down by the army.

The crisis began with the minister of finance's decision to stop setting the prices of grain at an artificially low and more affordable level. Freed from government price controls, merchants raised prices. Many people who could no longer afford this staple of their daily diet took to the streets in many cities, particularly around Paris. Violent protests erupted.

Why did the government want to reform France's agricultural production?

The king's finance minister had stopped setting the price of grain for a reason. He believed that low prices discouraged production and caused scarcity and, in turn, hunger. This had been a frequent problem. The new minister found inspiration in the principles of the Enlightenment and sought to reform France through rational, reasoned policies that put the latest knowledge to public use. He had the support of the king.

Agriculture was ripe for reform and improvement. The finance minister's goal was to increase production of grain by making it more profitable to grow. This was part of a larger reform effort to minimize government interference, simplify taxation, and increase efficiency. (Today, we would call these “free market” principles.)

French peasants and workers struggling to feed themselves and their families everyday reacted angrily to the price increases. Some decided to seize the grain and then sell it at what they saw as a fair price. Many of the poor even saw the government's action as an attempt to starve the lower classes and benefit the wealthy. The *parlement* (high court) of Paris objected to the legality of some of the reforms. Members of the middle class and nobility who benefited financially within the traditional system also felt threatened by the

new reforms. Their livelihoods affected, they too made their displeasure known.

The reforms were repealed, the minister of finance resigned, and his successors anxiously tried to avoid provoking protests. The Flour War illustrates the tightly tangled web that France was. Reform was needed, but changing the intricate and interconnected customs of the social, economic, and political spheres was no easy task. Despite his intentions to improve conditions, Louis XVI would prove neither confident enough nor decisive enough to implement change.

Financial Crises

The Flour War was one of many crises that would occur during the reign of Louis XVI. Many of these crises had financial causes. It was these financial problems that would expose the fault lines in French society and ultimately threaten the Old Regime and the rule of Louis XVI.

What were the causes of France's financial crises?

France was one of the great powers of Europe. Throughout the eighteenth century France had fought Great Britain in a series of wars. These wars were fought to gain wealth and power and prevent other countries from gaining power. At the same time, the wars were expensive. They became the primary source of France's financial difficulties. The wars extended to four corners of the globe and required France to have a powerful navy as well as an army. The government needed ways to pay for its expensive wars. For example, during the War of the Austrian Succession (1740-1748) the government introduced a new tax, which remained in place after the war ended.

Another war that began in 1756 ended poorly for France. Known as the Seven Years War, this war saw French military losses to Britain in India, Canada, and the Caribbean. In

the Treaty of Paris of 1763, France gave up all of its possessions in North America. Not only did this war cost France many of its overseas colonies, it had cost nearly twice as much per year as the previous war. The government had increased taxes, but was also forced to borrow money. When it turned out that the government could not repay its loans, it declared it would only pay back part of what it promised. (This is known as “writing off” debt.) This diminished confidence in the government. King Louis XVI decided that during his reign, writing off debt was something that he would avoid at all costs.

Why did France support the American Revolution?

The defeat suffered in the Seven Years War had wounded the pride of France. When thirteen of Great Britain’s North American colonies began to seek their independence, France saw an opportunity to restore its national pride while weakening Britain. King Louis XVI and his ministers certainly did not choose to support the North American colonies because of their basic aims, which included ending rule by the king and creating a more representative government. Instead they saw an opportunity to strike a blow at Britain’s power.

“Providence has marked out this moment for the humiliation of England.”

—Count Charles Gravier Vergennes, French foreign secretary, March 1776

France entered a formal alliance with the thirteen colonies in 1778. The French contributed men and financial support. All of this was funded by borrowing vast sums of money. The French navy played an important role in the decisive battle of the war at Yorktown in 1781 by preventing the encircled British forces from escaping by water. British forces surrendered at Yorktown and two years later, the 1783 Treaty of Paris gave the colonies their independence.

What effect did the American Revolution have on France?

Some of the ideas of the American rebellion were met with sympathy in France. Pamphlets like Thomas Paine’s *Common Sense* and the Declaration of Independence were widely read. Noted leaders like John Adams and Benjamin Franklin were welcomed as “friends of liberty.”

Another important effect was the high cost to France of supporting the American colo-

France’s Colonies in the Caribbean

In its pursuit of wealth and power, France had created colonies in North America, Asia, and the Caribbean. Though it had lost its colonies in Canada and India to Britain in 1763, it kept colonies in the Caribbean, including the islands Saint-Domingue (present-day Haiti), Guadeloupe, and Martinique. By 1789, Saint-Domingue produced more wealth than any other colony in the world. One in eight French people depended on commerce with the colonies to make a living.

The primary source of this wealth was the sugar grown on Saint-Domingue. Growing sugar was labor intensive and the French colonists relied on slaves brought from Africa. By 1789, there were 500,000 slaves, about 32,000 whites, and 28,000 free people of color on Saint-Domingue, which was smaller than the U.S. state of Maryland. (In comparison, there were about 700,000 slaves in the much larger United States at this time.) Conditions for slaves were extremely harsh. Although purchasing a slave was expensive, the sugar trade was so profitable that owners did not hesitate to work their slaves to death.

French law permitted and regulated slavery in its colonies. For example, non-Catholics were not allowed to own slaves and the laws, known as the “Black Code,” permitted brutal treatment of slaves. Slaves had no rights or privileges. Opposition to slavery grew very slowly in France and was led by a few French Enlightenment writers who criticized the harsh treatment of slaves.

nists. War was not cheap. France found itself unable to act on other foreign policy issues simply because it did not have the money to do so. France struggled to compete with Britain for a worldwide empire and the wealth that colonies brought. The high cost of its foreign policy put the government of France under severe strain. It desperately needed more money.

“It is impossible to tax further, ruinous to be always borrowing, and not enough to confine ourselves to economical reforms....”

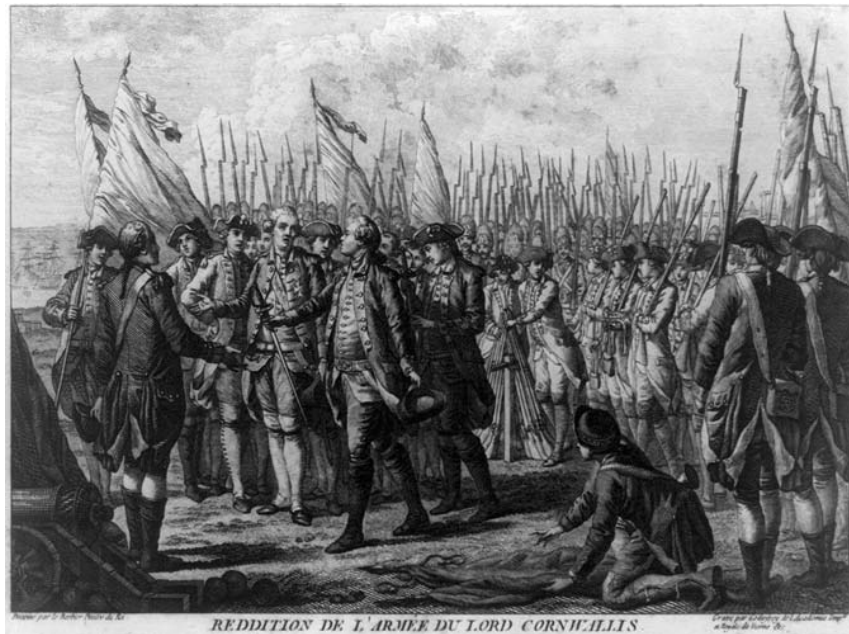
—Comptroller General
Charles Alexandre de

Calonne, August 20, 1786

The ongoing financial crises forced the government to take loans, and also to raise taxes. New taxes were never popular, but France’s complex system of administration and traditional privileges made collecting enough taxes to meet the government’s needs nearly impossible. For example, the privileged and most wealthy were exempt from taxation. The Catholic Church did not have to pay nor did the nobility. France’s system of privileges meant the burden of taxes fell on those least able to pay them.

There were other complications. Various regions of France were taxed at various rates. For example, the government taxed salt at six different rates. In some locations, residents were obliged to pay tax on a minimum amount of salt each year, even if they did not use or buy that amount of salt. The taxes and inconsistencies were deeply resented and difficult to administer; people tried to avoid paying them when they could.

Throughout the reign of Louis XVI and particularly during the 1780s, the government



This French engraving from 1784 shows the British army’s surrender at Yorktown. The French General Rochambeau directs the British General to give his sword to General Washington.

By François Godefroy and Jean Lebarbier. Library of Congress. Division of Prints and Photographs. LC-USZ62-2663.

found itself faced with increasing budget deficits (spending more money than it received). By 1788, 55 percent of government spending was going to payments on loans. The high amount of money owed made it harder to get more loans, and increasing taxes again would meet with resistance. The economy was reaching the breaking point.

Political Evolution

The financial challenges faced by France led to efforts to reform the system of government throughout the reign of Louis XVI. You have already read about the reforms that led to the Flour War in 1775. Other efforts at reform picked up again in the 1780s, made necessary by the worsening financial situation.

How did the role of public opinion change in France?

The public was well aware of the financial troubles. The effects of the crisis were hammered home to them in the form of unequal taxes and high prices for basic goods like bread. People expressed their feelings in a variety of ways: in public and private gather-

ings, in pamphlets or other writings, and even in demonstrations and riots.

Officials began to recognize the increasing importance of public opinion in politics. With the permission of the king, Minister of Finance Jacques Necker published an account of the budget of France in 1781. This made Necker extremely popular, but the release of the *Accounts of the King* actually misled the public by inaccurately claiming more revenues than expenditures.

“This report would also allow each of the people—who are part of YOUR MAJESTY’S Councils—to study and follow the situation of Finances. Such an institution could have the greatest influence on public confidence.”

—Minister of Finance Jacques Necker, 1781

Nevertheless, the very idea that the king’s accounts could be subjected to public scrutiny represented a significant evolution in French politics. Some of the king’s ministers thought that this threatened France’s absolute monarchy. They worried that it could lead to a government more like Great Britain’s constitutional monarchy. Although the king still regarded himself as an agent of God, his actions indicated that he considered the interests of his people as important.

What was the outcome of a proposal for sweeping reforms in 1786?

Louis XVI dismissed Necker in 1781. His successor’s efforts to increase taxes were resisted by the *parlements*. Louis XVI appointed Charles Alexandre de Calonne in 1783 as minister of finance. Calonne was able to borrow vast sums of money to keep the government running. But he realized that such massive borrowing could not continue much longer and, with the support of the king, proposed massive reforms.

“[W]ith matters as they are, ordinary ways being unable to lead us to our goal...the only means of managing

finally to put our finances truly in order, must consist in revitalizing the entire state by reforming all that is defective....”

—Comptroller General Charles Alexandre de Calonne, August 20, 1786

Calonne’s proposal had three parts. First, there would be a uniform tax system on landowners with no exemptions. He suggested that the new tax system be administered by new provincial representative assemblies. Second, to increase efficiency and productivity, he wanted to end internal customs controls and stop regulating the price of grain. Finally, Calonne realized that France would need to borrow money again until his reforms took effect. Knowing that the *parlements* were opposed to borrowing more money, he proposed that the king pick an Assembly of Notables to approve of these reforms.

What was the purpose of the Assembly of Notables?

France had a means to establish a representative forum to deal with national crises. The Estates General (whose members would be elected, not picked by the king) was meant to be a national representative body that could be called to meet by the king. No king had called an Estates General since 1614.

Calonne, whose reform proposals met resistance from the *parlements*, thought the Estates General might prove difficult to control. He hoped that this Assembly of Notables, made up of hand-picked members of the nobility, would support his proposals and influence public opinion to support his reforms. Things did not go according to plan.

The king called the Assembly of Notables to meet in January 1787. Although the delegates generally supported some of Calonne’s ideas, Calonne was personally and politically unpopular and met resistance. The assembly refused to approve the idea of additional loans without seeing estimates of the budget. When Calonne realized that he was failing to convince the assembly, he began to publish anonymous pamphlets against the notables,

who in turn complained to the king. The king, who had hoped that reforms could be passed, realized that neither Calonne nor the Assembly of Notables would solve France's problems. Pressure began to mount to call the Estates General.

Even as the Assembly of Notables ended, the king attempted to register some of Calonne's proposed reforms as new laws with the *parlements*. Some were accepted (including the provincial assemblies), but the *parlement* of Paris refused to accept new tax increases. Public interest was high and crowds gathered to hear the *parlement's* debate about the tax issue in August 1787. The king ordered troops to keep public order and exiled the *parlement* temporarily to the city of Troyes for its refusal to accept the new taxes.

The Estates General

As the financial crises worsened, political challenges continued. The king attempted to restructure the justice system by reducing the role of the *parlements*. Violent protests broke out. There was a vast public outcry against "despotism" (the use of absolute power in a cruel way).

Other factors contributed to the growing crises. Terrible storms during the summer of 1788 destroyed much of the grain harvest and pushed the price of bread through the roof. Hunger and hardship were widespread, particularly during the winter months.

“The wretchedness of the poor people during this inclement season surpasses all description.”

—The Duke of Dorset, January 8, 1789

There was increasing unrest and protest, which some believed could lead to civil war. Not only was France financially weak, the king's inability to lead France out of its troubles had weakened him in the eyes of many.

“The king is carried along endlessly from one policy to another, changing

them, adopting them, rejecting them with an inconceivable capriciousness; exercising force, then weakly retreating. He has entirely lost his authority.”

—Adrien-Cyprien Duquesnoy, May 1789

The refusal of financiers to lend the government any more money meant that France was approaching bankruptcy. The king agreed to call the Estates General, which would meet in May 1789. He also reappointed Jacques Necker, who remained immensely popular, as minister of finance. Necker announced an end to government controls on the press and publishing. This allowed public debate about the future of France to flourish.

Who were the deputies of The Estates General?

The Estates General was made up of three groups of deputies: the First Estate, which was the clergy; the Second Estate, the nobility; and the Third Estate, which represented everyone else.

Elections for the Estates General were held. The First and Second Estates voted for their representatives. Men over the age of twenty-five who were property holders were permitted to vote for delegates to the Third Estate. (There were members of the nobility elected to each of the Estates.) Members of the Estates General were male, and tended to be well-off and educated.

Traditionally, each of the Estates had one vote, even though the First Estate and Second Estates represented only about 300,000 out of a population of twenty-six million. Because the clergy and the nobility shared an interest in preserving their privilege, many in the Third Estate worried that they could be outvoted 2-1 if the other two Estates wished to block reforms favored by the Third Estate.

An intense public campaign began in pamphlets and newspapers demanding a greater role for the Third Estate, which would represent most of the population of France.



Hippolyte Prudhomme. Library of Congress. LC-USZ62-99705.

Opening of the Estates General at Versailles, May 5, 1789.

61. What is the Third Estate?

Everything.

2. What has it been heretofore in the political order? Nothing.

3. What does it demand? To become something therein."

—Abbé Sieyès,
What is the Third Estate? 1789

The king went along with public sentiment and agreed to double the number of representatives in the Third Estate from three hundred to six hundred, but did not change the number of votes per estate from one each. The First and Second Estates each had three hundred delegates.

What were the lists of grievances?

In addition to voting, voters also contributed to a "list" or "register of grievances" that would be taken to the Estates General by the newly-elected representatives.

The lists of grievances were assembled and compiled for the Third Estate's representatives in villages and towns throughout France. The grievances did not call for revolution. The most repeated themes were calls for fairness in taxation, a limit to the privileges of the nobility, and an end of tithes to the church. Many of them even expressed devotion to the king.

Women and Politics

The difficult economic conditions led many women to play an active political role during the early period of the French Revolution. Because women organized households and had an important role in feeding families, the shortages of bread spurred many to take political steps. For example, it was not uncommon for crowds led by women to seize bread and then to sell it at a "fair" price. Many working-class women participated in these demonstrations. Women who were well-off organized salons or meetings where political ideas were discussed. As France moved toward revolution, some believed that women should be given the same political rights as men. Many others were sceptical of that idea and thought that women should confine themselves to "traditional" roles.

“The lands of nobles and the church, should they not be submitted to taxation? Why subject the lands of poor people exclusively to it, and why thrust thus upon the Third Estate all the burden of taxation?”

—From the list of grievances of the community of Saint-Vincent-Rive d’Olt

What led to riots and violence in the spring of 1789?

As the Estates General prepared to meet, many of the people of France were frustrated. Shortages in the winter of 1789 had caused the price of bread to double.

“Monsieur, are they thinking of lowering the price of bread? I have eaten none for two days...it’s so dear.... Ah Monsieur don’t forget us, we will pray for you.”

—Unknown citizen in Paris to a delegate of the Estates General, April 27, 1789

Anger and resentment were widespread. There was a general distrust of the nobility, whom many assumed were trying to enrich themselves even if it meant starving the poor.

“Death to the rich! Death to the aristocrats! Death to the hoarders!”

—Crowd in Paris, April 27, 1789

In late April, violent riots broke out in Paris after the owner of a wallpaper factory was heard to say that lower bread prices would make it possible to lower wages. Apparently, he thought this would help the economy. His words quickly spread and led to protests, marches, and violence around the city. The army was called out to suppress the thousands who had taken to the streets. As the soldiers moved through Paris’s narrow streets after the crowds, hundreds of Frenchmen clambered to the rooftops and hurled stone shingles from the roofs at the soldiers. The soldiers began to fire on the crowds. Hundreds were killed and wounded.

“Liberty. Murderers! We won’t give way. Long live the Third Estate. Long live the king!”

—Crowd in Paris, April 28, 1789

There was violence not only in Paris, but across France during the spring of 1789. Peasants rioted against high grain prices, seized church property, and said they would refuse to pay the tithes of their harvests to the church. Starving peasants hunted wild game and took firewood from the estates of the nobility, things they were prohibited from doing. Tax offices were destroyed and many refused to pay the internal customs duties. Driven by hunger and fueled by resentment and mistrust of the privileged, the common people of France had struck a blow against those who they believed oppressed them. They had resisted the army and had stopped accepting the authority of the government.

As the Estates General prepared to meet, France faced insurrection (violent uprising). The traditions and institutions of France were being challenged by the peasants and workers, but also by the privileged classes who represented the Third Estate in the Estates General.

Why was the Estates General unable to make progress solving France’s problems?

The opening meeting of the Estates General took place on May 5, 1789. Each of the three Estates paraded in separately, wearing the clothing required by tradition. The First Estate (clergy) wore the robes of the clergy, the Second Estate (nobility) wore silk clothes, with gold cloth belts, swords, and white-plumed hats. The Third Estate (everyone else) were all in black.

The Estates General made little to no progress on the issues facing France. Much of its time was spent wrangling over whether each Estate would get one vote or whether each elected member of the Estates would get one vote, known as voting by head. A majority of the First and Second Estates opposed one vote per head, for though they represented a minority of delegates and of the French population, they hoped to preserve their ability to outvote

the Third Estate, 2-1. The Third Estate, with six hundred delegates, saw an advantage to voting by head.

The Estates met separately and debated what steps to take. While the nobility met in private, the Third Estate opened their sessions to the public. The debates were often chaotic. For example, the moderator of the Third Estate was once knocked to the floor by a group of deputies rushing to request a chance to speak.

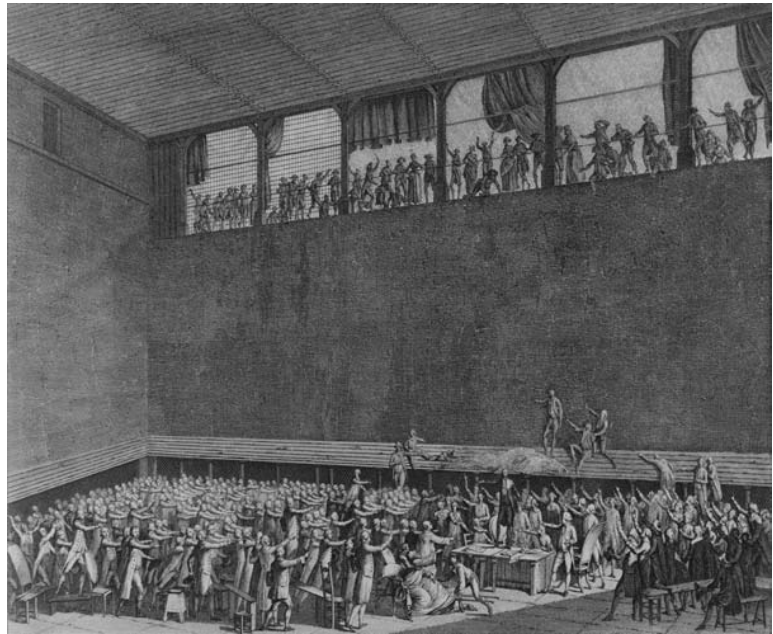
“[Imagine]...more than five hundred men thrown together in a room, brought in from different regions, unknown to one another, with no leader, with no hierarchy, all free, all equal, none with the right to give orders and none ready to obey them; and everyone in the French manner, wishing to speak before they listen.”

—Count Mirabeau, May 1789

The Third Estate tried to get the other Estates to meet with them, but the other Estates resisted at first. Abbé Sieyès, a member of the Third Estate, proposed that they call themselves the National Assembly and act on their own if the other two Estates would not join them. On June 19, the clergy voted to join the National Assembly.

What was the Tennis Court oath?

King Louis XVI had become frustrated at the lack of progress by the Estates General. He decided to call a meeting of all the Estates for June 23, 1789 where he would chart a course forward and assert his authority as king. He planned to use the hall where the Third Estate met for the meeting; it was large enough to hold all the delegates of all of the Estates. The king ordered the hall locked and prepared for the joint session of the Estates.



“Tennis Court Oath. June 20 1789.” This etching was done in 1789.

Pierre Gabriel Berthault. Library of Congress, Division of Prints and Photographs. LC-USZ62-117942.

When the delegates of the Third Estate arrived at their hall on the morning of June 20 and found it locked they reacted with anger. The king had not told the Estates what he was doing. The delegates feared the king planned to dissolve the assembly. They moved their meeting to a nearby indoor tennis court where they took an oath not to disband until a new constitution could be written.

How did the king respond to the Tennis Court Oath?

The king spoke to the full Estates General on June 23. The hall was surrounded by large numbers of soldiers. He proposed some reforms including trying to make the tax system fairer and ending arbitrary imprisonment. But he insisted that the three Estates continue to meet separately and that each have only one vote. He also said that the nobility and clergy had the right to veto any proposed changes to their privileges. He reminded the Estates that nothing they did was valid without his approval. He told the Estates to leave and resume meeting separately the next day and left the hall.

While the First and Second Estates filed out, the Third Estate remained as did some

members of the clergy. When they were reminded that the king had ordered them to leave, they refused.

“I declare that if you have been ordered to make us leave, you must seek orders to employ force, for we shall not leave except by the force of bayonets.”

—Count Mirabeau, June 23, 1789

The Fall of the Bastille

The king chose not to order the army to expel the delegates. But in the days that followed, he faced increasing turmoil and protests. Tens of thousands were on the streets in Paris intimidating and threatening those they saw as supporters of the Old Regime. Soldiers who had fired on rioters two months earlier now refused to help control the crowds.

On June 25, forty-eight nobles decided to sit with the National Assembly. Four days later the king changed course and decided to order the First and Second Estates to join the National Assembly. At Versailles, the king and the queen wept on their balcony as they were cheered by adoring crowds, who believed that the king truly supported reform.

“The whole business now seems over and the revolution complete.”

—Arthur Young,
British traveler,
June 27, 1789

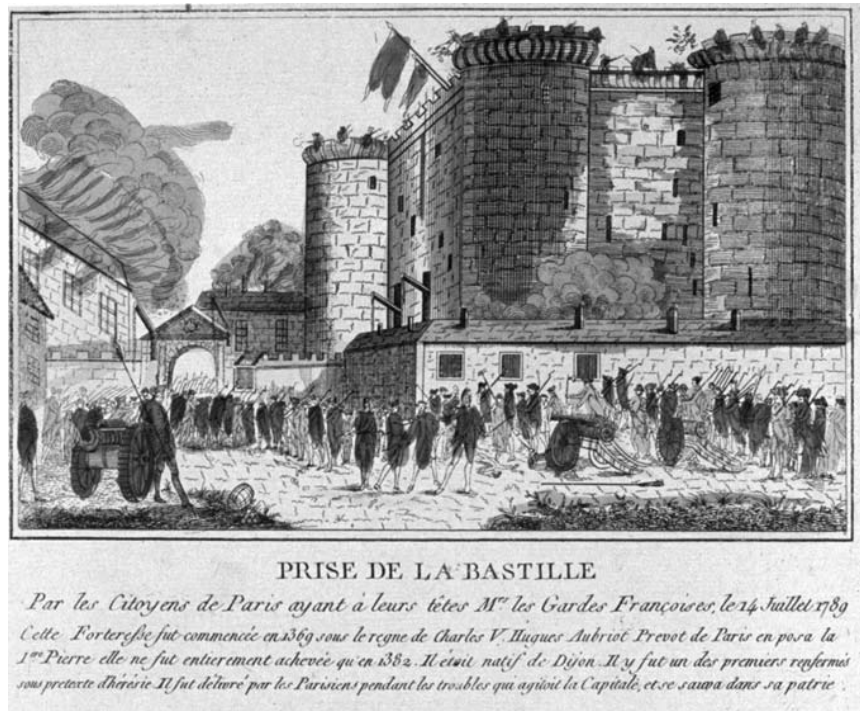
The revolution was not complete. In fact, it had just begun. While members of the National Assembly hoped finally to begin writing a constitution, popular unrest continued. Some members of the army in

Paris mutinied. As a consequence, the government ordered a military force of about twenty thousand from the border regions to Paris. Some of these soldiers were mercenaries (soldiers from other countries who had been hired by the king). Most believed that the mercenaries would be less reluctant to use force against French people than French soldiers. Members of the assembly worried that they would be arrested or even killed. Many people believed that the troops would forcibly disband the assembly.

What was the response to the king's decision to replace his ministers?

In Paris, nerves were stretched taut by the presence of so many troops. The king's decision to replace four of his ministers with more conservative ones proved to be a breaking point that prompted a powerful reaction from the people. One of the fired ministers was Jacques Necker, who was popular with many because he supported keeping the cost of bread low.

The king fired his ministers on July 11, 1789. The public discovered this the next day,



“The Taking of the Bastille by the Citizens of Paris....” This print was done in 1789.

a Sunday, when most were not at work. Crowds gathered and were attacked by foreign cavalry (soldiers on horses). In response, the crowds burned the toll stations around the city, which they associated with the high price of bread. Worried that the mercenaries would move against them, the people of Paris tried to get their hands on weapons wherever they could find them.

Why did crowds attack the Bastille?

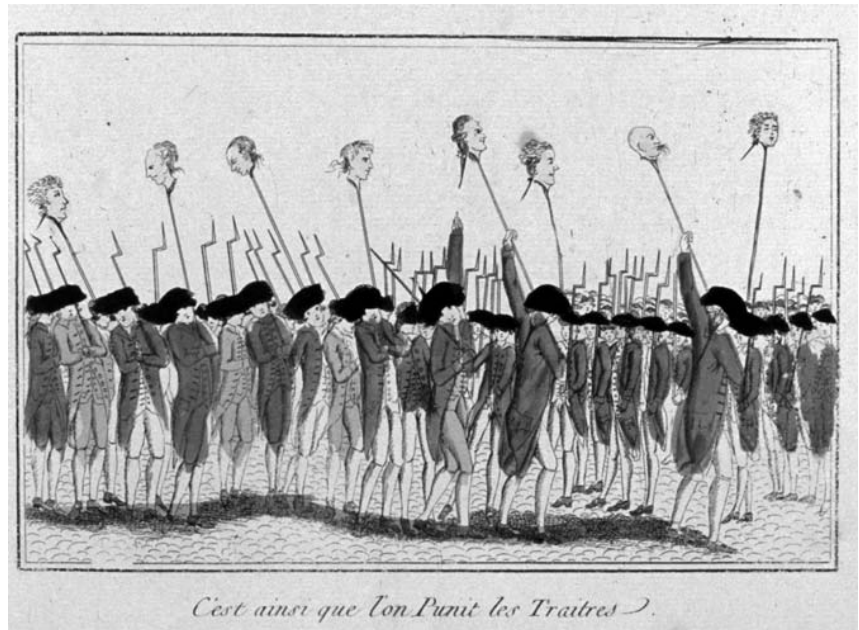
The search for weapons led the crowds, who had been joined by mutinous members of the army, to the gates of the Bastille. The Bastille was a prison, but also Paris's largest arsenal of gunpowder. An initial attempt to break in was unsuccessful. When the crowds dragged a captured cannon to the gates of the prison, the governor of the Bastille decided to surrender. About one hundred Parisians died attacking the Bastille; only one defender died. Crowds killed the governor of the Bastille, put his head on a pike, and paraded it through the streets. The king's ministers told him he could no longer rely on the loyalty of his soldiers.

“The defection of the army is not one of the causes of the Revolution, it is the Revolution itself.”

—Antoine Rivarol, writer, 1789

On July 15, the king told the National Assembly that he was ordering all troops withdrawn from Paris and agreed to work with the assembly. He also agreed to reappoint Jacques Necker as finance minister. His announcement was greeted with applause, cheers, and shouts of “long live the king.”

The members of the Estates General were



“This is how we punish traitors.” 1789.

Library of Congress, Division of Prints and Photographs, LC-USZC2-3565.

swept up in a tide of emotions. The fear of violence against them was temporarily replaced with patriotic fervor and hope. Nobles and clergy were now attending sessions of the assembly with members of the Third Estate. Newly renamed the National Constituent Assembly, it was now an integrated representative body of the three Estates.

When the king visited Paris on July 17, he accepted a red, white, and blue cockade (a decorative knot of ribbons), which was the symbol of the revolution. There were 150,000 citizens carrying weapons on the streets of Paris. When they saw the king wearing the revolutionary cockade, they cheered him.

What was the “Great Fear”?

During the second half of July 1789, the insurrection that had torn through Paris spread to about two-thirds of France. This period, which would last into August, has become known as the “Great Fear.”

Hunger and grain shortages drove many to desperation and violence. Rumors spread throughout the countryside among peasants that they would be attacked or their crops

stolen by bandits. Peasants lashed out against the tax system, refusing to pay tithes and even burning the records that showed how much they owed the nobility. Many peasants suspected the nobility of hoarding grain and of hiring criminals to steal their crops. Others thought that the British government was paying to incite riots throughout France. Unrest spread to small towns and cities. In the city of Rouen, textile workers destroyed machines that they thought might replace them in the factories. Rumors flew. Fear spread.

“There is no longer any governing authority and Louis XVI is no more king than you are.”

—Jean André Périsset Du Luc, member of the National Constituent Assembly, in letter to a friend, July 24, 1789

In its first weeks of existence, the National Constituent Assembly faced severe challenges. For the time being, the delegates were united by hope and the desire for change. Nevertheless, the economic and political problems that had led to insurrection throughout France remained. The assembly had integrated the three estates into a single representative body. Now would come the challenge of fixing the problems facing France.

“The union existing among the three orders, held together by a rapprochement of ideas and a unity of desires,...will eliminate the arrogant and destructive principles of the aristocracy.... Frenchmen of all ranks and all classes bring to an end the vain distinctions which have divided them and will unite to build the foundations of freedom and happiness.”

—Antoine-François Delandine, member of the National Constituent Assembly, July 1789

Members of the Constituent Assembly were proud they had integrated all the three Estates. Many shared a sense of optimism and hope for the future. But the task of constructing a new France would prove formidable.

“It is not enough to destroy; we have to rebuild and I confess that the task frightens us.”

—Jacques-Athanase de Lombard-Taradeau, member of the National Constituent Assembly, August 13, 1789

In Part II of the reading, you have explored the origins of France’s financial crises. You have seen how these crises created momentum for reform and political change. By 1789, all segments of French society, the peasants, clergy, bourgeoisie, and the nobility were caught up in the process and uncertainties of a changing France. The authority of the king had been undermined and the king himself appeared to accept a new role for the assembly. In truth, he had little choice in the matter. The assembly faced the daunting challenge of creating a new system of government while trying to deal with instability and the continuing economic crisis.

The National Constituent Assembly and the Future of France

The deputies faced the enormous task of trying to develop a new constitution while governing a country torn by unrest and fear. They began working long days. New city governments were formed throughout the country and support for the National Constituent Assembly increased. Some deputies felt overwhelmed by the size of their task.

“I am far from sharing the optimism of some of our colleagues. The masses of starving people, the numbers of discontented, the difficulties of every sort imaginable...all combine to discourage me.”

—Jean-François Campmas, member of the National Constituent Assembly, August 13, 1789

As stories of the Great Fear spread, the assembly made a radical decision. Swept up by the spirit of reform and working late into the night on August 4, 1789 the assembly decided to end many of the privileges of the nobility. The deputies hoped that this would calm the peasants and decrease unrest. Some also hoped that it would reduce the power of the nobility, particularly those they worried were out to end the revolution. In a single evening, the assembly upended the centuries-old social hierarchy of France. Some historians believe that this was the most significant result of the French Revolution.

Many of the rights and privileges of the nobility were eliminated. For example, the assembly (which included nobles) ended the system of dues and taxes that peasants had to make to the nobility. These had been deeply resented and had appeared often in the “lists of grievances.” The nobility’s exclusive hunting rights and private tolls also were

abolished. The deputies ended the payment of tithes and the purchase of public offices. In theory, positions would be obtained based on ability.

“In the future, only wealth, talent, and virtue will distinguish one man from another.... We are a nation of brothers. The king is our father and France is our mother.”

—Claude Ganneret, member of the National Constituent Assembly, letters of August 5 and 11, 1789

A few voices in the assembly of more than a thousand also called to end slavery in France’s colonies, to give Protestants full religious freedom, and to ban nobility outright.

These issues were not acted on, but would become issues for debate in the coming months. After the assembly’s action, unrest in the countryside slowly began to decrease.

“Men are born and remain free and equal in rights.”

Declaration of the Rights of Man and Citizen

Why did the deputies write the Declaration of the Rights of Man and Citizen?

On the afternoon of August 4, the deputies had agreed to write a preface to the new constitution as quickly as possible. After several weeks of discussion, prolonged by members of the clergy reluctant to allow complete freedom of worship, the assembly voted to approve this preface, now called the Declaration of the Rights of Man and Citizen. The document was influenced by the Virginia Declaration of Rights written in 1776 by George Mason. The Declaration of Rights of Man and Citizen promised liberty and equality to citizens and emphasized the need for constitutional protections for these rights. It also said that sovereignty (the right to rule) rested in the people of the nation and not just the king.



"Quick, quick, quick
Hit it while it's hot
quick, quick, quick
Keep at it!

Our hearts must be in the work."

This print shows the Three Estates working cooperatively to forge the new constitution.

The approval of the Declaration of the Rights of Man and Citizen raised many important questions and issues about how to interpret and enact this document. What was the role of the king? Did he have the final say (or veto power) over new laws? What exactly was a citizen? Who would be eligible to vote? Were women citizens? Did they have equal rights? Should there be a bicameral legislature? Should there be religious freedom in France? If men are born and remain free, should slavery be abolished?

What were the divisions in the assembly?

As the assembly began to consider just what the principles laid out in the Declaration

meant, three factions began to emerge. The differences that had been temporarily put aside in the revolutionary fervor of July had resurfaced.

The first group made up the majority of the assembly and were considered moderates. This group believed the revolution was over and imagined that France would become a constitutional monarchy, perhaps like Great Britain.

A second and much smaller group of conservative nobility and clergy thought that maybe the revolution had gone too far. They believed that the king should retain his authority and that the privileges renounced on August 4th by nobility and clergy should be reclaimed.

The third group was also a small minority of the assembly. These were the radical "patriot" deputies, who wanted more rights for all. For example, they wanted political rights and legal equality for Protestants. It is important to note that they did not argue for ending the monarchy.

The seating of the assembly was arranged in an oval with the president sitting on one side. The conservatives sat to the right of the president, the radical patriots to the left. The moderates, in the middle. This is the origin of the political terms we use today: conservatives are referred as the "right"; moderates are called "the center"; liberals are referred to as the "left."

In the coming days, you will recreate the debate among these three groups as they tried to write a new constitution for France.

You will consider whether the king should have a veto over laws and who is eligible to vote. You will consider questions of religious freedom, the role of women in politics, the role of the Catholic Church and religion in society, and whether slavery should be ended in the colonies.

The actual debates took place over a period of months and were complicated by the fact that the assembly needed to govern France as well as write a constitution.

The people of France followed the arguments in the assembly closely. The number of newspapers had increased from one daily paper in 1777 to more than thirty by end of 1789. Those who could not read could go hear the news read aloud in public. All over France, people formed political clubs where they argued about the issues in front of the assembly.

While the members of the assembly, most of whom were well-off, began to debate the future of French government, the people of France followed events closely. As you will see, they would find ways to make their opinions known.

“Overwhelmed with responsibilities and distracted by endless contingencies, we must work now on one question, now another, despite our strong desire to concentrate on one issue at a time.”

—Jacques-Athanase de Lombard-Taradeau,
member of the National Constituent
Assembly, October 15, 1789